

OpenClaw VPS Setup — Quick Guide

What you need: Laptop, credit card (~\$12/mo), Telegram account, Claude Max/Pro or Anthropic API key. Takes ~45 min.

1. Tailscale (Your Private Tunnel)

1. Create account: <https://login.tailscale.com> (free)
 2. Install on YOUR computer:
 3. Mac: <https://tailscale.com/download/mac>
 4. Windows: <https://tailscale.com/download/windows>
 5. Linux: `curl -fsSL https://tailscale.com/install.sh | sh && sudo tailscale up`
 6. Save your Tailscale IP: `tailscale ip -4` → looks like `100.x.x.x`
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2. SSH Key (Your Digital ID)

```
ssh-keygen -t ed25519  
cat ~/.ssh/id_ed25519.pub
```

Copy the output — you'll paste it when buying the server.

3. Buy the VPS

1. Go to <https://www.ionos.com/servers/vps> → pick **VPS L** (~\$12/mo)
 2. Settings: **Ubuntu 24.04 LTS**, paste your SSH key from Step 2
 3. Wait for email with your server's **public IP**
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4. First Login + Tailscale on Server

```
ssh root@YOUR_PUBLIC_IP
```

Install Tailscale on the server:

```
curl -fsSL https://tailscale.com/install.sh | sh  
sudo tailscale up
```

Open the printed URL in your browser → approve the device.

Get your server's Tailscale IP:

```
tailscale ip -4
```

Save this IP — it replaces the public IP from now on.

Go to <https://login.tailscale.com/admin/machines> → find your server → **Disable key expiry**.

Test from a new terminal on your computer:

```
ssh root@YOUR_SERVER_TAILSCALE_IP
```

5. Lock Down the Server

```
apt update && apt upgrade -y
adduser openclaw
usermod -aG sudo openclaw
mkdir -p /home/openclaw/.ssh
cp ~/.ssh/authorized_keys /home/openclaw/.ssh/
chown -R openclaw:openclaw /home/openclaw/.ssh
chmod 700 /home/openclaw/.ssh && chmod 600 /home/openclaw/.ssh/authorized_keys
```

Test it works (new terminal):

```
ssh openclaw@YOUR_SERVER_TAILSCALE_IP
```

Harden SSH (as `openclaw` user):

```
sudo nano /etc/ssh/sshd_config
```

Change these lines:

```
PermitRootLogin no
PasswordAuthentication no
PubkeyAuthentication yes
MaxAuthTries 3
```

```
sudo systemctl restart sshd
```

Firewall:

```
sudo apt install -y ufw
sudo ufw default deny incoming
sudo ufw default allow outgoing
sudo ufw allow in on tailscale0
sudo ufw enable
```

Finally — go to <https://my.ionos.com> → Firewall Policies → **delete ALL rules** (TCP 22, 80, 443, everything).

6. Install Docker

```
sudo apt install -y docker.io docker-compose-v2
sudo systemctl enable --now docker
sudo usermod -aG docker openclaw
exit
```

Log back in, then verify:

```
ssh openclaw@YOUR_SERVER_TAILSCALE_IP
docker run hello-world
```

7. Install OpenClaw

```
mkdir -p ~/video-workspace/{clips,assets,output,projects,fonts,templates}
git clone https://github.com/openclaw/openclaw.git ~/openclaw-setup
cd ~/openclaw-setup
export OPENCLAW_DOCKER_APT_PACKAGES="ffmpeg chromium xvfb x11vnc novnc fonts-liberation fonts-noto-regular"
export OPENCLAW_EXTRA_MOUNTS="$HOME/video-workspace:/home/node/video-workspace"
./docker-setup.sh
```

Onboarding wizard answers:

Question	Answer
Continue?	y
Gateway type?	Local gateway
Workspace?	Enter (default)
Gateway bind?	Loopback (127.0.0.1)
Auth?	Token
Token?	Enter (auto-generate)
DM policy?	Pairing
Skills?	Skip

 **Save the gateway token it generates.**

8. Single Container Setup

```
nano ~/openclaw-setup/unified-entrypoint.sh
```

Paste this:

```
#!/bin/bash
set -e
Xvfb :99 -screen 0 1280x720x24 -ac &
sleep 1
export DISPLAY=:99
chromium --no-sandbox --disable-gpu --headless=new \
  --remote-debugging-address=0.0.0.0 --remote-debugging-port=9222 \
  --user-data-dir=/home/node/.chromium-profile &
sleep 2
x11vnc -display :99 -nopw -forever -shared -rfbport 5900 &
/usr/share/novnc/utils/novnc_proxy --vnc localhost:5900 --listen 6080 &
exec node dist/index.js gateway --bind "${OPENCLAW_GATEWAY_BIND:-lan}" --port 18789
```

```
chmod +x ~/openclaw-setup/unified-entrypoint.sh
cp ~/openclaw-setup/docker-compose.yml ~/openclaw-setup/docker-compose.yml.backup
nano ~/openclaw-setup/docker-compose.yml
```

Delete everything, paste this:

```
services:
  openclaw:
    image: ${OPENCLAW_IMAGE:-openclaw:local}
    container_name: openclaw
    environment:
      HOME: /home/node
      TERM: xterm-256color
      DISPLAY: ":99"
      OPENCLAW_GATEWAY_TOKEN: ${OPENCLAW_GATEWAY_TOKEN}
    volumes:
      - ${OPENCLAW_CONFIG_DIR}:/home/node/.openclaw
      - ${OPENCLAW_WORKSPACE_DIR}:/home/node/.openclaw/workspace
      - openclaw-home:/home/node
      - ./unified-entrypoint.sh:/app/unified-entrypoint.sh
    ports:
      - "${OPENCLAW_GATEWAY_PORT:-18789}:18789"
      - "${OPENCLAW_BRIDGE_PORT:-18790}:18790"
      - "127.0.0.1:6080:6080"
    init: true
    restart: unless-stopped
    entrypoint: ["/bin/bash", "/app/unified-entrypoint.sh"]

volumes:
  openclaw-home:
```

```
rm -f ~/openclaw-setup/docker-compose.override.yml
nano ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

Find or add the browser section:

```
"browser": {
  "enabled": true,
  "cdpUrl": "http://127.0.0.1:9222"
}
```

```
cd ~/openclaw-setup
docker compose down && docker compose up -d
docker compose ps
```

You should see ONE container named `openclaw` with status "Up".

9. Telegram Bot

1. Open Telegram → search **@BotFather** → send `/newbot`
2. Follow prompts, save your **bot token**
3. Configure it (if not done in wizard):

```
nano ~/.openclaw/openclaw.json
```

Add to channels:

```
"channels": {
  "telegram": {
    "enabled": true,
    "token": "YOUR_BOT_TOKEN",
    "dmPolicy": "pairing"
  }
}
```

```
docker compose restart openclaw
```

10. Pair Your Account + Connect Claude

Message your bot "hello" on Telegram → it sends a pairing code.

```
docker exec openclaw node dist/index.js pairing approve telegram YOUR_CODE
```

Connect Claude:

```
# On your LOCAL computer:
claude setup-token

# Back on VPS:
docker exec -it openclaw node dist/index.js models auth paste-token --provider anthropic
docker compose restart openclaw
```

Paste the token using **right-click** → **Sanitize and Paste** (avoids token cutoff).

Test: message your bot "hello, how are you?" — it should respond.

11. Auto-Updates

```
sudo apt install -y unattended-upgrades
sudo dpkg-reconfigure -plow unattended-upgrades
sudo nano /etc/apt/apt.conf.d/50unattended-upgrades
```

Find and uncomment these lines:

```
Unattended-Upgrade::Automatic-Reboot "true";
Unattended-Upgrade::Automatic-Reboot-Time "04:00";
```

```
sudo systemctl enable-linger openclaw
```

Done ✓

Your agent is live. Access from your computer only:

What	How
Dashboard	<code>ssh -N -L 18789:127.0.0.1:18789 openclaw@TAILSCALE_IP → open http://127.0.0.1:18789/?token=TOKEN</code>
Browser viewer	<code>ssh -N -L 6080:127.0.0.1:6080 openclaw@TAILSCALE_IP → open http://127.0.0.1:6080</code>
Logs	<code>docker compose logs openclaw --tail 20</code>
Restart	<code>docker compose restart openclaw</code>
Stop	<code>docker compose stop</code>

Stuck? See the full guide: *OpenClaw VPS Setup — Complete Guide*